

✦ **STUDY BEES** ✦

POEM – BLUE

by

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About the Poem

Title	Blue
Poet	Brian A. Haycock
Source	Unit 8 of the textbook
Type	Narrative (story-telling) lyric poem
Speaker / Voice	A father, speaking in the first person
Structure	6 stanzas (quatrains) of 4 lines each = 24 lines
Rhyme Scheme	AABB in every stanza (rhyming couplets)
Central Idea	A father's unconditional love for his blind daughter and his struggle to explain the colour blue to her
Tone	Tender, emotional, reflective, hopeful

Summary of the Poem

"Blue" is a touching poem told by a father about his daughter. It opens with joy at her birth: she is soft, pink and beautiful, with her father's eyes, her mother's nose and brown hair. As months pass, the parents sense that something is wrong. A doctor phones and reveals that the baby was born blind. The father first weeps, then feels angry because this is not the fatherhood he had imagined. Soon, however, he accepts the situation and promises to become her eyes and 'heart of sight'.

The girl grows into a bright, curious child and her father spends every day teaching her all he knows. One day she asks him what blue is. He tries to explain, but all his words depend on sight, and for the first time he feels he has failed her. The poem ends on a hopeful note: as she grows older, she builds her own idea of blue in her mind, wanting to understand what others see, and for her that idea becomes real.

Difficult Words

Word	Meaning
Plight	a difficult, unfortunate situation
In vain	without success; useless
Sighted	able to see; based on vision
Settled down	became calm and quiet
Concern	worry, anxiety
Reality	something real and true (not just imagined)



Stanza 1 (Lines 1–4)

Paraphrase

The father describes the day his daughter was born. She was pink and soft, with tiny toes. Her eyes looked like his and her nose looked like her mother's. She cried for a short while and then became calm. He calls her the angel of his life and mentions her brown hair.

Theme of the Stanza

Joy and pride of new fatherhood; the innocence and beauty of a newborn.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	toes / nose (A); down / brown (B)	Perfect rhymes. Lines 1–2 rhyme with each other and lines 3–4 rhyme with each other.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Anaphora	The first three lines begin with the same word, 'She', giving a gentle, rhythmic, loving introduction.
Metaphor	'Angel of my life' compares the baby to an angel – pure, precious, a blessing.
Imagery	Visual and tactile images (pink, soft, tiny toes, brown hair) help us picture the baby.
Family resemblance	Sharing eyes and nose with the parents shows the father's bond with his child.

Tone

Warm, tender, proud, joyful.

Stanza 1 – Questions & Answers

Q1. Who is the speaker and who is 'she'?

Ans. The speaker is a father; 'she' is his newborn daughter.

Q2. What features of the baby does the father mention?

Ans. She is pink and soft, has tiny toes, her father's eyes, her mother's nose and brown hair.

Q3. Why does the father call the baby an angel?

Ans. It is a metaphor showing how pure, precious and special she is to him.

Q4. What is the mood of the first stanza?

Ans. Happy and loving; there is no hint of trouble yet.



Stanza 2 (Lines 5–8)

Paraphrase

Months go by and the parents watch their baby grow. They begin to feel that something is wrong and that they must find out what. The doctor phones with worry in his voice and tells the father that his 'angel' was born blind.

Theme of the Stanza

The shock of discovering the child's disability; the turning point of the poem.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	grow / know (A); mind / blind (B)	Perfect rhymes. The word 'blind' falls at the end of the stanza, giving it strong emphasis.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Contrast (antithesis)	The happy mood of stanza 1 sharply changes to worry and bad news.
Understatement	'Something was wrong' hints at trouble without naming it, building suspense.
Repetition / metaphor	'My angel' is repeated to show the father still sees her as perfect and precious.
Emphasis by placement	Ending on 'blind' delivers the news like a sudden blow.

Tone

Anxious, worried, then serious and heavy.

Stanza 2 – Questions & Answers

Q1. What did the parents feel as months went by?

Ans. They felt something was wrong with their child and knew they had to find out the truth.

Q2. Who told the father about the child's condition and how?

Ans. The doctor phoned him, speaking with concern, and told him the baby was born blind.

Q3. How does the tone change in this stanza? (While-reading question)

Ans. The joyful, tender tone of the first stanza turns worried, serious and sombre once the doctor gives the news.

Q4. Why is the phrase 'my angel' repeated?

Ans. It shows the father's love has not changed; the news hurts because she was so precious to him.



Stanza 3 (Lines 9–12)

Paraphrase

The father cries for a while and then becomes angry. Having a disabled child was not what he had imagined fatherhood would be. But from that day on he commits himself to a new duty: to be her eyes in life and the heart that guides her sight.

Theme of the Stanza

Emotional struggle – grief, anger and finally acceptance and determination; a parent's duty and sacrifice.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	mad / dad (A); plight / sight (B)	Perfect rhymes. The rhyme of 'plight' and 'sight' links his struggle to her lack of vision.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Metaphor	'Be her eyes in life' – he will see the world on her behalf and describe it to her.
Paradox / metaphor	'Heart of sight' suggests that sight can come from love and feeling, not only from the eyes.
Parallelism	The father's crying echoes the baby's crying in stanza 1, showing how their lives are now linked.
Assonance	The repeated long 'i' sound in 'cried' and 'while' adds to the flow.

Tone

Shocked and angry at first, then determined and resolute.

Stanza 3 – Questions & Answers

Q1. How did the father react to the news?

Ans. He cried for a while and then became angry.

Q2. Why was the father angry?

Ans. The situation was not his idea of being a dad; it broke his expectations of fatherhood.

Q3. What does 'to be her eyes in life and her heart of sight' mean?

Ans. He decides to help her understand the world by seeing for her, guiding and describing things with love.

Q4. What change do you see in the father in this stanza?

Ans. He moves from grief and anger to acceptance and a strong sense of responsibility.



Stanza 4 (Lines 13–16)

Paraphrase

As the years pass, the girl grows into a beautiful child who is curious and eager to learn. The father spends every day teaching her everything he knows. Then, one day, she asks him a simple question: what is blue?

Theme of the Stanza

Growth and curiosity of the child; the father's devotion as her teacher; introduction of the central question.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	grow / know (A); knew / blue (B)	Perfect rhymes. 'Blue', the key word of the poem, appears in the last rhyme.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Imagery	'Beautiful child' gives a pleasant picture of the girl growing up.
Repetition (polyptoton)	Know / knew are forms of the same verb, stressing knowledge and learning.
Symbolism	'Blue' stands for the world of sight and experiences that lie beyond her reach.
Foreshadowing	Ending with her question hints that the father will face a challenge.

Tone

Proud, affectionate and hopeful, ending in suspense.

Stanza 4 – Questions & Answers

Q1. How did the girl grow up?

Ans. She grew into a beautiful child with a strong wish to know and understand.

Q2. How did the father spend his days?

Ans. He spent each day teaching her everything he knew.

Q3. What question did she ask one day?

Ans. She asked him about the colour blue.

Q4. Why is the last line of this stanza important?

Ans. It introduces the main conflict; the title colour becomes a problem the father must solve.



Stanza 5 (Lines 17–20)

Paraphrase

The father tries to explain what blue is but his efforts fail. The only ways he knows to describe things are based on sight, and she has no way of understanding what he is trying to say. For the very first time, he feels he has failed her.

Theme of the Stanza

The limits of language and of sight-based experience; helplessness and a father's sense of failure.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	vain / explain (A); say / day (B)	Perfect rhymes; both couplets stress the failure and the day it happened.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Irony	A father who has taught his daughter everything cannot explain a simple colour because his words depend on sight.
Emphasis / climax	'For the very first time' marks this as a painful moment in an otherwise successful journey.
Contrast	His confident teaching in stanza 4 is set against his helplessness here.
Abstract idea made human	Colour, something we take for granted, becomes a barrier between father and child.

Tone

Frustrated, helpless, regretful and sad.

Stanza 5 – Questions & Answers

Q1. Why did the father's efforts to define blue fail?

Ans. He could only use sighted descriptions, which a blind child cannot connect to anything she has experienced.

Q2. What does 'sighted descriptions' mean?

Ans. Explanations that depend on seeing, such as comparing colours to visible things.

Q3. How did the father feel at the end of this stanza?

Ans. He felt that he had failed his daughter for the first time.

Q4. What does this stanza tell us about language?

Ans. Words are limited; they cannot fully convey an experience the listener has never had.



Stanza 6 (Lines 21–24)

Paraphrase

Time goes on and the girl keeps growing. She forms her own thoughts about what blue is. She longs to know what others can see, and inside her mind her idea of blue becomes real for her.

Theme of the Stanza

The power of imagination and inner vision; every person's perception is personal; hope, resilience and understanding beyond sight.

Rhyme Scheme

Scheme	Rhyming words	Note
A A B B	grew / blue (A); see / reality (B)	'Grew/blue' is a perfect rhyme; 'see/reality' is a near (approximate) rhyme, since 'reality' ends in a weak '-ee' sound.

Figures of Speech & Devices

Device	Explanation
Symbolism	'Blue' now symbolises understanding and the inner world that exists beyond sight.
Paradox	A blind girl 'sees' blue in her mind; she understands what she cannot see.
Abstract imagery	'Inside her mind it became reality' shows imagination turning into truth.
Open ending	The poem never says what her blue is like, leaving it to the reader's imagination.

Tone

Reflective, hopeful, uplifting and bittersweet.

Stanza 6 – Questions & Answers

Q1. What does the girl do as she grows older?

Ans. She forms her own ideas and thoughts about what blue is.

Q2. What does she want to know?

Ans. She wants to know what others can see.

Q3. What is the meaning of 'inside her mind it became reality'?

Ans. Her imagined idea of blue felt real and true to her, even without physical sight.

Q4. Why does the poet not tell us what her blue is?

Ans. Because her understanding is personal; the open ending shows that perception is individual and imagination is powerful.



Character Sketches

The Father (Narrator)

- Loving and devoted: he calls his daughter the 'angel of my life'.
- Human and honest: he admits that he cried and then got angry when he heard the news.
- Determined and selfless: he promises to be her eyes and spends every day teaching her.
- Humble: he openly says he failed her when he could not explain blue.

The Daughter

- Born blind, but bright, curious and eager to know.
- Imaginative: she builds her own idea of blue in her mind.
- Resilient: she wants to understand what others can see instead of giving up.

The Doctor

- A minor character who phones the family with the diagnosis.
- Shown as caring – he calls 'with concern' – and his news changes the poem's tone.

The Mother

- Mentioned only once (the baby has her nose) and in the word 'we' as the parents watch the child grow.

Themes of the Poem

- **Parental love:** the father's love does not change, even when life turns out differently from what he expected.
- **Disability and acceptance:** the poem moves from shock and anger to acceptance and commitment.
- **Limits of language:** words that depend on sight cannot explain a colour to someone who has never seen.
- **Imagination and inner vision:** the girl 'sees' blue in her own way through her mind.
- **Growth and resilience:** both father and daughter grow stronger through challenges.
- **Perception is personal:** everyone experiences the world differently, and no one way is more 'real'.



Literary Devices – Overview

Device	Where / Example	Effect
Metaphor	'Angel of my life'; 'be her eyes'; 'heart of sight'	Shows deep love and the father's role as guide
Anaphora	Stanza 1: three lines begin with 'She'	Gentle rhythm; focus on the child
Imagery	Pink, soft, brown hair, beautiful child	Creates a clear picture of the girl
Symbolism	Blue	Stands for sight, experience and understanding
Irony	Stanza 5: sight-based words used for a blind child	Highlights the father's helplessness
Paradox	'Heart of sight'; she 'sees' blue in her mind	Shows understanding beyond the eyes
Contrast	Joy (st. 1) vs. bad news (st. 2)	Marks the turning point
Understatement	'Something was wrong'	Builds suspense before the news
Repetition	Grow, know / knew, angel, cried	Reinforces central ideas
Assonance	'Cried' / 'while'	Adds musical quality
Foreshadowing	End of stanza 4	Prepares us for the father's challenge

Rhyme Scheme Chart

Stanza	Scheme	Rhyming pairs
1	AABB	toes–nose, down–brown
2	AABB	grow–know, mind–blind
3	AABB	mad–dad, plight–sight
4	AABB	grow–know, knew–blue
5	AABB	vain–explain, say–day
6	AABB	grew–blue, see–reality (near rhyme)



Tone & Style

Tone (stanza by stanza)

Stanza	Tone / Mood
1	Tender, proud, joyful
2	Anxious, worried, serious
3	Shocked, angry, then determined
4	Proud, affectionate, hopeful
5	Frustrated, helpless, regretful
6	Reflective, hopeful, bittersweet

Overall tone

The poem is emotional and reflective. It begins with joy, moves through shock, anger and frustration, and ends with quiet hope and admiration for the girl's imagination.

Style

- **Narrative and first-person:** the father tells the story in order, from birth to childhood and beyond.
- **Simple, conversational language:** everyday words make the emotions honest and easy to relate to.
- **Structure:** six quatrains, each with a clear step in the story (birth, diagnosis, reaction, growth, failure, insight).
- **Rhyme:** AABB rhyming couplets throughout, giving a song-like, story-telling rhythm.
- **End-stopped lines:** most lines finish with a natural pause, adding to the calm, honest voice.
- **Central symbol:** the title colour 'blue' gives the poem its focus.



Pre-reading & While-reading Answers

Pre-reading

Q1. What emotions or themes might be present in a poem titled 'Blue'?

Ans. 'Blue' is often linked with sadness, calm, the sky and the sea. So we might expect themes of sorrow, loneliness, peace, or feelings connected with colour. (In the poem it becomes a symbol of sight and understanding.)

Q2. Based on the title and author, what do you anticipate the poem might be about?

Ans. Students may guess it is about sadness or the sea. The poem is actually about a father and his blind daughter.

Q3. How might the narrator's perspective influence the poem?

Ans. Because a father tells the story in the first person, it is personal, emotional and full of love, worry and pride.

While-reading

Q1. What details stand out in the opening lines?

Ans. The baby's pink, soft skin and tiny toes, her father's eyes, her mother's nose, brown hair, and the phrase 'angel of my life'.

Q2. How does the tone change when the doctor delivers news about the child?

Ans. It shifts from joyful and tender to worried, serious and sombre.

Q3. What emotions does the narrator experience, and how are they conveyed?

Ans. Joy and pride (stanza 1), worry (2), sadness and anger (3), determination and love (3–4), frustration and guilt (5) and hope (6). They are conveyed through word choice (cried, mad, plight, in vain, failed), contrast between stanzas, and the honest first-person voice.



Extra Questions & Answers

Q1. What is the central idea of the poem?

Ans. A father's unconditional love for his blind daughter, and how imagination lets her understand the world in her own way.

Q2. Why is the poem titled 'Blue'?

Ans. Blue is the colour the girl asks about and the father cannot explain. It symbolises sight, experience and the understanding that language cannot always give.

Q3. Describe the father's journey through the poem.

Ans. He moves from joy at her birth, to shock and anger at the news, to acceptance and commitment as her guide, to frustration when he fails, to quiet hope as her imagination grows.

Q4. What is ironic about the father's failure?

Ans. He has taught her everything, yet cannot explain one colour because all his descriptions rely on sight.

Q5. What message does the poem give?

Ans. Love, patience and imagination can overcome obstacles; there are many ways of understanding the world, and sight is not the only one.

Q6. How does the poet show the father's love?

Ans. Through the 'angel' metaphor, his promise to be her eyes, his daily teaching and his honest sorrow at failing her.

Q7. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem?

Ans. Every stanza follows AABB, using rhyming couplets.

Q8. Write a short note on the ending of the poem.

Ans. The ending is open and hopeful. The girl creates her own 'blue' in her mind, and the poet lets readers imagine what it is like, showing that understanding can come from within.

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